



MONTHLY UPDATE

DR Congo: monthly update, August – September 2026

Edition of 2026-09-10 · compiled by Claude Opus from the documents in the Corpus repository

Developments summarised from sources published between the beginning of last month and today.

SUMMARY OF THE MONTH · GOVERNANCE · FINANCE · ICT INFRASTRUCTURE · DPI · DIGITALISATION · TECHNOLOGY
· CAPACITY · INCLUSION · DATA

Summary of the month

Two strategies were validated and not adopted, and a third was adopted without being seen. The sectoral digital economy policy 2026-2030 and the national artificial-intelligence strategy [were presented and validated by government at a Kinshasa ceremony on 4 August](#), both awaiting adoption; a [national connectivity strategy for 2026-2035 was published on 13 August](#); and the Council of Ministers [adopted a strategy for the protection of the information space on 28 August](#), whose text is not held.

The Digital Code moved from statute to prosecution. [Prosecutors were instructed to open cases under it without a complaint](#) and the prosecutor general [mobilised judicial police officers against offences committed on social media](#), while an awareness campaign for the same code [was launched in Kinshasa](#). In the east, [mobile and internet service has been off across Fizi territory since 3 July](#). The universal service fund meanwhile [signed subsidy conventions with four operators for a first tranche of 40 localities](#).

Governance

Strategies, plans and policies

Experts validated the [sectoral digital economy policy 2026-2030 on 21 and 22 July](#), subject to completing the [costing, indicators and institutional responsibilities](#). A restitution workshop on 29 and 30 July presented a ten-dimension maturity diagnostic and named the [instruments to be articulated: the digital and data strategies, the AI strategy, the identity platform, the sovereign cloud, a certification authority and a cybersecurity agency](#), plus a rule barring AI platform deployment without data quality, auditability and human supervision.

The connectivity side of that framework acquired numbers in August. The universal service fund [published a National Connectivity Strategy 2026-2035 built on a shared-infrastructure model led by a tower company](#), and [signed subsidy agreements with the four mobile operators to extend service to 40 underserved localities covering about 258,000 people](#), against a target of 3,000 localities and 16 million people by 2030. The strategy text is not held, and neither the subsidy amounts, the tower company nor the selection rule for the first 40 localities is stated.

Legislation and regulation

The [interministerial order on digital-sector duties, taxes and fees](#) was in force on signature on 20 July under its article 5. It sets a two-tier dollar schedule keyed to whether a provider is judged dominant, running from US\$2,500 to US\$15,000 for cloud services and US\$25,000 to US\$100,000 for data-centre declaration, with one startup line at US\$100. It was [suspended by government communiqué](#) on 3 August. Neither the gazetted order nor the suspending communiqué is held.

Two regulators agreed on 22 July to [form joint inspection teams and enforce local-content subcontracting rules on large operators](#), scoped beyond telecoms to digital services and e-commerce; no written protocol is held.

The digital code is being applied to speech. On 15 August the justice minister [restated the government's determination to clean up Congolese cyberspace and said prosecutions were already under way for public insults and defamation on social platforms under the Code du numérique](#), after receiving an NGO memorandum on 13 August. No case number, charge or judgment is held.

A new schedule of [taxes, permits and sanctions now governs the digital sphere](#). The base holds a legal analysis of it rather than the instrument, so the issuing authority, the instrument number and the entry-into-force date are not established here.

Data protection

Data protection has an authority that does not exist, a code that is now being prosecuted, and a population whose service does not reach it. The prosecutor general [mobilised judicial police officers against offences committed on social media](#) – enforcement against speech running ahead of any body protecting the data the same code governs. In the east, [mobile and internet service has been off across Fizi territory, Baraka included, since 3 July, with a press-freedom call for restoration on 17 August](#). It is reported as war damage rather than an ordered restriction, and no licensing or administrative decision for occupied territory is held.

Regional collaboration

The [African Telecommunications Union's return to Kinshasa was ratified on 23 July at the union's plenipotentiary conference in Abuja, after the country paid more than US\\$1.4m in arrears](#). No date for the move is stated, the arrears figure and the account are the minister's own, and a bid for a seat on the ITU's administrative council for 2027 to 2030 is still pending.

Standards

The telecoms regulator [installed equipment giving it near-real-time access to mobile operators' own data](#) on service quality, traffic flows and spectrum, which the ministry says will let it establish breaches objectively rather than on operators' own reporting. No first enforcement action or published measurement has followed.

Public debate and participation in policymaking

A [standing consultation mechanism between the ministry and the sector network was agreed at a working session on 6 August](#), after the dispute over the digital-sector tariff. No constituting text, membership or meeting schedule is stated, and the agreement is known from a communiqué carried by the state news agency.

The audiovisual and communications council and the press-freedom council [formalised an institutional partnership by memorandum](#) after two days of work on 19 and 20 August 2026. No work programme, joint power or first action under it is on file.

Finance

Domestic budget appropriations and expenditure

The money behind the finance inspectorate's digitalisation is domestic. The US\$22 million presented in May as already-identified financing [is the state's own allocation rather than donor money](#), its inspecteur général chef de service confirmed. That distinction matters for a programme whose durability depends on whether it survives a budget cycle rather than a grant period; the record held carries no disbursement schedule against it.

MoUs and other agreements

The month's one signed arrangement puts a commercial bank inside the digital ministry's programme. The digital economy ministry and a commercial bank [signed a memorandum on 13 August to modernise the financial sector and accelerate banking inclusion](#), covering digital identity and artificial-intelligence integration under the 2019 national digital plan and the 2023 Digital Code. No term, value, workplan or data-protection provision is published — for an arrangement that names digital identity as in scope.

New investments

A development fund committed [US\\$32.8m into an upsized US\\$179m senior secured facility on 5 August](#), funding 728 new passive towers to take the network to 1,800, 70% of them rural, with solar and battery upgrades. [The same lender committed US\\$30m to the same borrower in 2023, when the network stood at 1,072 active towers.](#)

ICT Infrastructure

Connectivity

Deployment of the transformation project's fibre backbone was reported to the Council on 3 August: [7,000 km laid against more than 18,500 km, leaving 11,500 km outstanding](#) and tied to connecting 145 territories by 2030. The minister attributed the pace to budget constraints and a low disbursement rate on external financing, blamed on donor procedure.

Coverage arrived from orbit before it arrived by fibre. An operator [commercially launched a satellite-to-mobile service on 14 August, the first African operator to take the technology out of testing](#): a compatible LTE Android handset with a clear view of the sky reaches messaging and SMS through satellites where there is no terrestrial network, with no dish, router or other equipment, and the [regulator has confirmed a phased rollout](#). The service is stated as designed for light data, and the only access term published is a [free 30-day trial for customers who register through the operator's app](#); no standing tariff, coverage map or subscriber figure is on the record.

Starlink users in Kinshasa [face four to six months of possible slowdowns while the network is congested](#). No subscriber count, capacity figure or remediation date accompanies the notice.

A cross-border route was reaffirmed rather than started. The Tanzanian and Congolese foreign ministries [agreed to fast-track a fibre-optic cable from Kigoma to Kalemie in Tanganyika province through Lake Tanganyika, alongside a standard gauge railway link through Burundi and the establishment of a joint economic commission](#). The statement came at a farewell meeting for the Congolese ambassador in Dar es Salaam; no route survey, cost, financing, landing point or delivery date is published, and no Congolese ministry statement is on file.

Technical Capacity

Assembly capacity for digital hardware appears in this base for the first time, as a framework rather than a plant. The coordination office of the Kinshasa expansion project and an Algerian-led consortium agreed a memorandum on 30 August for an assembly and production facility at Maluku covering electronic payment terminals, cash machines and computers, with an innovation centre for payment technologies, cybersecurity and applied artificial intelligence and vocational training attached. No investment figure, production capacity or construction timetable is stated, so what is signed is an intention to cooperate rather than a commitment anyone can be held to.

DPI

Data Exchange

The exchange being built is between revenue agencies rather than between citizens and the state. The finance inspectorate disseminated a three-year strategic plan to public administrations, with data cross-checking between revenue agencies under systemic control. No platform, data-sharing instrument or protection arrangement for the cross-checked records is named.

Digital Identity and CRVS

Identification in the window is a provincial operation rather than a national one. Training of the agents for an operation registering Mbororo herders in Nord-Ubangi closed at Gbadolite on 17 August. Registering a named population as a distinct category is a decision with consequences beyond the register, and no legal basis, data controller, retention rule or purpose limitation is published for it.

Continently, the laboratory system the country's current Ebola response runs on was assessed before the outbreak began. A multi-country study covering 26 countries found every one with a functioning surveillance system and core diagnostic capacity and 3,964 laboratories mapped across fourteen, and named digital interoperability between laboratories and surveillance platforms — alongside specimen referral, workforce surge and domestic financing — as the weak points, which is where the response has had to improvise. It is a reference study written up by its own author rather than a dated development here, and the base holds no national laboratory-interoperability position to set against it.

Digital Payments and Fintech

Fare collection took its first digital step. The state bus operator Transco opened the trial phase of QR-code electronic ticketing in Kinshasa on 31 August, its director general scanning the first code on the inaugural run. It is a trial on one operator's buses. No fare volume, route coverage or payment provider is named, and nothing connects it to the national payment rails.

Registries

Business formalisation was inspected on 28 July: the portal proposes a legal form and tracks a file in real time and the application issues sole-trader attestations in under 48 hours, while full online company creation is not possible.

Two further registers were announced as part of a financial-sector package rather than as builds. A modernised credit-risk registry and an electronic movable-collateral registry are to be built with the central bank, alongside a new deposit-guarantee fund, in a World Bank programme to expand financing for small and medium firms that also carries a rollout of 10,000 point-of-sale terminals and agent networks. No instrument, custodian, timetable or access rule is stated for either registry, and no data-protection provision is reported for the credit file.

The registry ground also drew a vendor. A Kenyan platform operator [pitched the digital economy ministry on 12 August on digital company registries, beneficial-ownership traceability and real-time state-revenue tracking](#), citing its own deployments in Malawi and South Sudan; the minister asked officials to continue talks toward a partnership. It is a sales meeting, and the claims in it are the vendor's.

The company that built the vehicle identification platform [is refusing to hand it to the government without compensation](#) and is preparing legal action in Belgium after a mediation attempt failed. A state registry whose operating platform the state does not control is a governance exposure and not only a commercial dispute; no contract terms, valuation or filing date is on file.

A second registry-shaped system was announced on the certification side. The standards control office [plans a national QR-code system letting consumers scan a product – medicines included – to verify its certification status, with consumer checks stated as opening within weeks and resting on 88 laboratories across 29 sites](#). No launch date, register, cost or enforcement route is published, and the laboratory counts are the office's own.

Sectoral management information systems

Enforcement caught up with the standardised electronic invoice. The finance minister [closed the fiscal clinics and ordered immediate targeted sanctions against non-compliant taxpayers and against tax-administration staff](#).

Naming the administration's own staff alongside the taxpayers is the part worth recording; no compliance rate, sanction count or invoice volume is published.

The revenue side of the digitisation put a number on itself. On a broadcast accountability programme on 3 September the finance minister said [monthly value-added tax collection had passed FC 320bn against an average of FC 280bn – about US\\$141.4m a month – attributing the rise to generalised e-filing at the tax directorate and the phased rollout of the standardised invoice](#). The attribution is his own, with no counterfactual, compliance rate or invoice-volume series behind it. In the same broadcast he named [the interconnection of the three revenue agencies and a data warehouse as under way, alongside a digital public-finance programme he put at more than US\\$150m to be built with a Chinese network vendor](#) – the largest figure attached to any digital programme the base holds for the country, and one with no contract, procurement route, scope document or timetable published behind it.

Other GovTech and e-Gov

The month's only movement in government platforms was a procurement, and not the state's own: Belgium's development agency [opened a tender on 1 August for artificial-intelligence modules to be built into the national employment agency's platform](#), for job matching aimed at youth unemployment, with offers due on 7 September. No contract value, award or delivery date is on record, and the digital government platform it would sit beside remains at Planned with its target already missed.

Digitalisation

Rural digital data capture

A three-week digital enrolment pilot in April [replaced paper forms with application-based capture across 20 primary schools in Kasai and registered 8,634 pupils, among them disabled and pregnant or mother students the paper system had not counted](#). Making the uncounted visible is what the trial was for; twenty schools is its whole extent, and no national rollout, device count or connectivity provision is published.

Technology

AI

The national artificial-intelligence strategy [was presented and validated by government at a Kinshasa ceremony on 4 August](#), alongside the sectoral digital economy policy. Validated is not adopted: no adoption date is established and the text is not held.

Underneath the strategy, one piece of actual capability began. [Collection of Lingala language data for artificial intelligence was launched alongside the digital code campaign](#). No corpus size, licence, custodian or consent arrangement for the speakers' contributions is stated.

Innovation ecosystem

A government communiqué of 3 August confirmed that the [Startup Act implementing texts remain in preparation](#): four draft decrees adopted in May 2025 to operationalise the fiscal, customs and exchange advantages of the 2022 ordinance-law, none in force fifteen months on. None of the four texts is held.

Capacity

Literacy

A [campaign to publicise the digital code launched in Kinshasa on 6 August, mobilising 2,000 young volunteers for 30 days at two publications a day](#) on cybersecurity, data protection and responsible internet use, carried by the ministry with UNDP support. The code was promulgated in March 2023, and no budget for the campaign and no measure of its effect is stated.

Training and skills

The employment office launched a [portal and mobile application in July](#) on which jobseekers register skills and employers post needs, intended to build a national skills database. It was externally financed, and no user or placement figure is held.

The digital economy ministry [opened the first of a planned series of five-day training sessions for 580 of its own agents and managers](#) at the INPES in Kinshasa on 24 August 2026. No curriculum, completion target or budget line is published.

The land ministry [closed a roughly month-long course for 50 conservators of property titles on 25 August, drawn from several provinces and run with the national school of administration as part of a capacity-building programme under the land reform](#), setting it alongside archiving operations already running in seven pilot land districts of Kinshasa; no further wave or provincial timetable is stated.

Research institutions

The national university's transdisciplinary research programme [awarded its excellence prize on 29 August to a project building an artificial-intelligence and spatial-analysis decision-support tool for traffic governance in Kinshasa](#). It is applied digital research produced inside a Congolese department rather than commissioned abroad. No domestic public funding line for digital or artificial-intelligence research is held.

Inclusion

Access to services

On 23 July a state bank and the payroll monitoring committee settled the technical and organisational terms for [paying civil servants in rural territories, scoped to three named territories and others where no other bank operates](#). August 2026 was named as a target, with the bank's director-general calling a fixed date premature and the state contract unsigned. What subscribers pay moved the other way. Users and resellers in Bukavu say a [1GB bundle that ran 48 hours at 1,500 Congolese francs now expires in 24 at the same price](#), and a 2GB 48-hour bundle at 2,000 francs has been replaced by 1GB over 72 hours; subscribers across the eastern provinces [report the same pattern across four operators and have asked a consumer body to intervene](#). Both ends are subscribers' accounts; no operator or regulator has stated anything.

Accessibility entered the record as an argument about a process rather than a system. A tribune set out [six levers for deaf participation in the national dialogue relaunched on 17 July 2026 – interpretation, captioning, accessible documents and the rest – on the ground that a democracy that speaks without being understood has already excluded part of its citizenry](#). No public data on deaf access to state processes is held, which is what makes the piece the base's only statement on the question.

Digital divides

This is the month's clearest movement with both ends dated. The universal service fund [signed subsidy conventions with four operators on 8 August for a first tranche of 40 localities, about 258,000 people](#), against a national diagnostic published the day before finding nearly 3,000 uncovered localities – about 4.3m people – and coverage of 77% 2G, 68% 3G and 57% 4G. A [second phase of 300 sites is planned, with a 2030 target of 3,000 localities and 100 digital community centres](#). An unfunded fund at the window's start, a first funded tranche at its end; no per-locality budget or fund appropriation figure is held. The diagnostic's own spread is wide: [coverage runs from about 98% in Kinshasa to 14% in Tshuapa and 28% in each of Kwango and Sud-Ubangi](#), and the fund is [drafting a national strategy that prioritises investment by coverage gap, population, economic activity, public infrastructure and geography, naming the Lobito, National and Peace corridors as its three strategic routes and shared passive infrastructure as its approach](#). No adoption date, budget or target is published for it.

Data

National statistics

The planning minister [announced recruitment of mapping agents and fixed general enumeration for July 2027](#), which would be the country's first census since 1984. No budget line, financing source, implementing contract or cartography completion figure is held. Separately a [digital sector barometer was announced after a working session on 6 August](#) to give government figures on firms' activity, turnover, growth and job creation – proposed by the industry body rather than imposed by the state, with no operator, methodology or first-issue date stated.

Open data

The month's one open-data movement came from the central bank rather than from the state's open-data policy, which the base still does not hold. The bank [relaunched its website on 14 August as a public economic-data portal carrying exchange rates, inflation, interest rates, statistics and indicators, with a currency converter and a search facility](#), its governor framing the site as part of a reform whose stated objectives include digitalising payments and automating control processes. It is a publication channel rather than a data release: no machine-readable download, licence or update schedule is stated, and the national data governance strategy remains **Not held**.

The gap the open-data portal does not cover was named from outside government. The national academy of sciences called for a [national policy on the management and security of environmental data, setting the absence against an observing network that carried more than 125 synoptic weather stations and 400 hydrometric stations in the 1960s, few of which still work](#). It is an academic call rather than a government commitment: no draft, sponsoring ministry or timetable exists, and the station counts are the study's own historical figures — which is itself the finding, since nothing more recent is published.

Use of satellite data

Two routes into earth observation opened in the window, one contracted and one already running. [MapBiomass launched a Congolese land-cover mapping programme on 18 August](#), and behind it sits a satellite the country does not yet have: [a contract to supply, commission and maintain the RDC-SAT earth-observation satellite for the National Centre for Remote Sensing was signed in Kinshasa in June, framed as supporting agriculture, mining and forestry monitoring](#). No launch date is on the record.

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